Saved by Grace

God, rich in mercy, made us alive in Christ when we were dead in sin; salvation is his gift, not our achievement, and it makes us his workmanship for good works.

Main passage	Ephesians 2:1-10 (KJV)
Topic	Grace of God
Audience	adults
Length	about 45 minutes
Status	Draft: written by AI from the library, not yet reviewed by Dave

Suggested timing

Opening	4 min
Scripture	3 min
Background	5 min
Teaching point 1: We were dead, and could not save ourselves	7 min
Teaching point 2: But God, rich in mercy, made us alive	7 min
Teaching point 3: Saved for good works	7 min
Discussion questions	7 min
Application	3 min
Closing prayer	2 min
Total	45 min

Opening (4 min)

Ask: "What is the best gift you ever received that you did nothing to earn?" After a few answers, ask: "How did it feel to receive something you could not pay back?" Some people find gifts hard to accept; we like to earn things. Today's passage is about the greatest gift of all and why we cannot earn it.

Scripture (3 min)

Ephesians 2:1-10

[1] And you hath he quickened, who were dead in trespasses and sins; [2] Wherein in time past ye walked according to the course of this world, according to the prince of the power of the air, the spirit that now worketh in the children of disobedience: [3] Among whom also we all had our conversation in times past in the lusts of our flesh, fulfilling the desires of the flesh and of the mind; and were by nature the children of wrath, even as others. [4] But God, who is rich in mercy, for his great love wherewith he loved us, [5] Even when

we were dead in sins, hath quickened us together with Christ, (by grace ye are saved;) [6] And hath raised us up together, and made us sit together in heavenly places in Christ Jesus: [7] That in the ages to come he might shew the exceeding riches of his grace in his kindness toward us through Christ Jesus. [8] For by grace are ye saved through faith; and that not of yourselves: it is the gift of God: [9] Not of works, lest any man should boast. [10] For we are his workmanship, created in Christ Jesus unto good works, which God hath before ordained that we should walk in them.

Read the passage aloud. Ask the class to listen for the two words "But God" in verse 4, the turning point of the passage.

Background (5 min)

Paul wrote to believers in Ephesus, a large city in what is now Turkey and the home of the great temple of Diana (Artemis). Most of the church had been pagans. In chapter 1 Paul praised God for every spiritual blessing in Christ. In chapter 2 he reminds them where they started and what God did.

The passage moves in three steps: what we were (vv. 1-3), what God did (vv. 4-9), and what we are now for (v. 10). Paul includes himself ("we all", v. 3). Jew and Gentile, religious and irreligious alike, needed rescue.

Teaching point 1: We were dead, and could not save ourselves (7 min)

Paul does not say we were sick or weak; he says we were "dead in trespasses and sins" (v. 1). We were following the world's way, the devil's lead and our own desires. A dead person cannot help bring himself back to life. That hard truth is the background that makes grace good news.

Supporting verses

Ephesians 2:1-3: And you hath he quickened, who were dead in trespasses and sins; Wherein in time past ye walked according to the course of this world, according to the prince of the power of the air, the spirit that now worketh in the children of disobedience: Among whom also we all had our conversation in times past in the lusts of our flesh, fulfilling the desires of the flesh and of the mind; and were by nature the children of wrath, even as others.

Romans 3:23: For all have sinned, and come short of the glory of God;

Romans 5:12: Wherefore, as by one man sin entered into the world, and death by sin; and so death passed upon all men, for that all have sinned:

> *"As they were corrupt in their nature, and sinful in their practice, they could possess no merit, nor have any claim upon God"*
>
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Ephesians 2:4

Handout blanks (answers)

Without Christ we were **dead** in trespasses and sins.

We could not save **ourselves**.

Teaching point 2: But God, rich in mercy, made us alive (7 min)

"But God" changes everything. Because of his great love, God made us alive together with Christ and raised us up with him. The reason is in God, not in us: he is "rich in mercy." Salvation is by grace, his undeserved favour, received through faith. It is "the gift of God," so no one can boast.

Supporting verses

Ephesians 2:4-9 (read from the Bible)

Romans 5:8: But God commendeth his love toward us, in that, while we were yet sinners, Christ died for us.

Titus 3:4-7: But after that the kindness and love of God our Saviour toward man appeared, Not by works of righteousness which we have done, but according to his mercy he saved us, by the washing of regeneration, and renewing of the Holy Ghost; Which he shed on us abundantly through Jesus Christ our Saviour; That being justified by his grace, we should be made heirs according to the hope of eternal life.

> *"Mercy is the riches or the wealth of God."*
> — Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Ephesians 2:4

> *"By mere favour. It is not by your own merit; it is not because you have any claim."*
> — Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Ephesians 2:8

Handout blanks (answers)

God is rich in **mercy**.

By grace are ye saved through **faith**.

Salvation is the **gift** of God, not of works.

Teacher note: Christians understand the relationship between God's grace and our faith in somewhat different ways (for example, whether faith itself is the "gift" in verse 8). All agree on what this lesson teaches: we are saved by God's grace, not by our own merit, and receive it through faith.

Teaching point 3: Saved for good works (7 min)

Verse 10 is the other side of verses 8-9. We are not saved by good works, but we are saved for them. We are God's "workmanship." The Greek word gives us our word "poem": we are his handiwork, created in Christ for a life of good works that he has prepared. Good works are the fruit of grace, not the price of it.

Supporting verses

Ephesians 2:10: For we are his workmanship, created in Christ Jesus unto good works, which God hath before ordained that we should walk in them.

Titus 2:11-14: For the grace of God that bringeth salvation hath appeared to all men, Teaching us that, denying ungodliness and worldly lusts, we should live soberly, righteously, and godly, in this present world; Looking for that blessed hope, and the glorious appearing of the great God and our Saviour Jesus Christ; Who gave himself for us, that he might redeem us from all iniquity, and purify unto himself a peculiar people, zealous of good works.

James 2:17-18: Even so faith, if it hath not works, is dead, being alone. Yea, a man may say, Thou hast faith, and I have works: shew me thy faith without thy works, and I will shew thee my faith by my works.

> *"We are his making"*
> — Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Ephesians 2:10

> *"Every converted sinner is a saved sinner."*
> — Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Ephesians 2:4-10

Handout blanks (answers)

We are God's **workmanship**, created in Christ Jesus.

We are saved not by good works but **for** good works.

Discussion questions (7 min)

1. Why do you think Paul begins with such a dark picture (vv. 1-3) before the good news?

We cannot appreciate grace until we see our need; a rescue means most to those who know they were drowning.

2. What do the words "But God" (v. 4) mean to you personally?

Answers will vary; invite testimony of how God intervened.

3. Why does it matter that salvation leaves no room for boasting?

It keeps us humble, makes everyone equal at the foot of the cross, and gives all the glory to God.

4. How do verses 8-9 and verse 10 fit together?

Grace saves us apart from works; the same grace then produces good works in us. Works are the fruit, not the root.

Application (3 min)

Thank God every day this week, in your own words, for one specific thing his grace has done for you. Then look for one "good work prepared in advance" (v. 10): someone to help, encourage or serve. Do it as a thank-you to God, not to earn anything.

Closing prayer (2 min)

Merciful God, we were dead in our sins, but you loved us and made us alive in Christ. Thank you for grace we could never earn and a gift we could never repay. Keep us from boasting in anything but your mercy. Make us your workmanship, and lead us into the good works you have prepared for us. In Jesus' name, Amen.

Sources quoted

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Ephesians 2:4

Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Ephesians 2:4

Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Ephesians 2:8

Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Ephesians 2:10

Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Ephesians 2:4-10

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